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Disaster Mobility: Post-Cyclone Idai Mobility in Mozambique and Zimbabwe

*A Comparative Analysis of Countries and Mobility
Actors*

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GLOSSARY OF TERMS

Term	Definition	Source
Displacement	The movement of a person who has been forced to flee their place of residence to avoid the consequences of violence, armed conflict, and natural or human-made disasters.	IOM (2019)
Disaster displacement	‘The movement of persons who have been forced or obliged to leave their homes or places of habitual residence because of a disaster or to avoid the impact of an immediate and foreseeable natural hazard’.	IOM (2019)
Climate migration (working definition)	‘The movement of a person or groups of persons who, predominantly for reasons of sudden or progressive change in the environment due to climate change, are obliged to leave their habitual place of residence, or choose to do so, either temporarily or permanently, within a State or across an international border’.	IOM (2016), The Nansen initiative (2015)
Internally displaced persons (IDPs)	‘Persons or groups of persons who have been forced or obliged to flee or to leave their homes or places of habitual residence, in particular as a result of or in order to avoid the effects of armed conflict, situations of generalized violence, violations of human rights or natural or human-made disasters, and who have not crossed an internationally recognized State border’.	(Deng (1998); IOM (2019)

INTRODUCTION

1.1 BACKGROUND and CONTEXT

In March of 2019, Cyclone Idai struck across Southern Africa, becoming one of the most severe climate disasters of the region. It largely affected populations in Mozambique and Zimbabwe and triggered widespread displacement requiring long term settlement needs. Mozambique suffered the highest losses on the African continent since 2019, with reconstruction costs estimated at US\$2.9 billion.

Despite similarities in exposure, both countries exhibited markedly different displacement management strategies and, subsequently, mobility outcomes. The trajectories of movement that unfolded afterwards were complex and occurred over months and years. In accordance with existing literature (Hilhorst, 2018 and Barnett's, 2011), these trajectories were a result of not just the physical exposure to the hazard, but rather, due to the interaction between national governance frameworks, humanitarian actor dynamics and community level constraints. Understanding these interactions is useful to understand why some populations returned quickly, while others moved repeatedly or remained immobile long after the disaster.

This thesis analyses post-Cyclone-Idai mobility through a mixed methods and multiple source approach. Quantitative data from the International Organisation for Migration (IOM) Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM/IDM) baseline round surveys in the study area provides high-resolution evidence of site-level population change, volatility and return patterns. Qualitative, textual data from news media, social media and humanitarian reporting offer insight into how mobility was framed, interpreted and communicated to the public. The triangulation of these datasets examines how government, humanitarian and community interventions shaped mobility and how these processes and outcomes were represented (or misrepresented) in public narratives.

1.2 STATE OF THE ART

Research on disaster-induced mobility has shifted from environmental determinism to multi-causal, institutionally informed accounts that treat movement as a spectrum from immobility and temporary coping to secondary displacement and return (Huang et. al., 2025). Contemporary frameworks emphasise interactions among hazard exposure, social vulnerability, governance choices, and livelihood constraints, and they foreground both individual decision processes (e.g., threat and coping appraisals) and structural drivers (infrastructure, markets, policy).

Theoretical advances cluster around a few complementary lenses: protection-motivation and capability approaches that explain household choices, vulnerability and cascading-risk frameworks that situate shocks within longer-term degradation, and translocal perspectives that show how local actors negotiate national and international policy prescriptions (Fekete, 2025). These lenses help explain why similar hazards produce divergent mobility outcomes across places.

Empirically, two primary patterns recur, clearly documented in the UNHCR report by Gemene et. al (2021). First, visible, episodic movements as evacuations, concentrated resettlement, and assisted returns are well captured by operational reporting and media. Second, persistent immobility and protracted displacement are under-documented: many households remain in place because of costs, documentation loss, livelihood dependence, or social ties, and these conditions are often invisible to donors and the press (Gemenne, 2021, Fekete, 2025). Return itself is heterogeneous (temporary, assisted, coerced) and requires time-sensitive, disaggregated measurement.

As the IOM (2023), among other literature, states, governance and institutional capacity matter. Where legal frameworks and dedicated disaster authorities are stronger, responses tend to be more coordinated and produce visible, centralized site dynamics. Weaker institutionalisation often yields reactive relief and dispersed host-community solutions. Methodologically, this thesis is adopting mixed-methods designs that combine longitudinal monitoring (DTM/IDM), qualitative fieldwork, and digital trace analysis (news, social media, humanitarian texts). Digital methods provide high-velocity signals but carry language, platform, and representativeness biases that require triangulation and manual validation.

This thesis addresses three persistent needs in the literature: 1) better documentation of immobility, 2) comparative analysis of governance effects, and 3) methodological integration of operational and digital sources by triangulating IDM time-series with multilingual media and third-sector reporting to compare Mozambique and Zimbabwe.

1.3 RESEARCH AIM and QUESTIONS

Main Question

How did the interaction between national governance frameworks and humanitarian actor dynamics shape post-disaster mobility outcomes across a spectrum of movement (from immobility to return) following Cyclone Idai in Mozambique and Zimbabwe?

Sub Questions

1. How are Zimbabwe and Mozambique different in mandated pathways of post disaster mobility and actual mobility patterns after Cyclone Idai?

This question examines the formal mobility pathways established by each government such as resettlement sites and host communities, then compares them to the observed mobility patterns captured in the IDM data.

2. To what extent do the role, contributions and effectiveness of interventions in public media narratives align with the specific sentiments expressed by the community and third sector separately?

This question assesses whether traditional institutional actors (represented in news media coverage), community discourse (represented on social media) and humanitarian reporting reflect or distort the realities of displacement and recovery dynamics.

3. What do the datasets reveal about the reality of immobility and return versus publicly available documentation?

This question examines the gap between measured mobility outcomes through IDM data and the narratives presented in humanitarian reports and news coverage.

1.4 SIGNIFICANCE OF STUDY

This research contributes to the growing field of disaster mobility by:

- providing a comprehensive analysis of disaster mobility as a spectrum beyond binary movement
- showing how governance and humanitarian interventions shape disaster mobility
- analysing how media narratives report lived displacement realities
- revealing the underreported immobility in public and institutional narratives
- providing a dual comparative analysis of disaster mobility across countries and actors
- presenting a mixed methods framework for studying disaster mobility using quantitative econometric analysis and leveraging digital research methods (DMI)

1.5 STRUCTURE OF THE THESIS

The thesis is structured as follows:

- Chapter 2 reviews relevant literature on displacement, mobility, and humanitarian governance
- Chapter 3 outlines the methodology and data analysis approach
- Chapter 4 presents the results
- Chapter 5 discusses the findings in relation to the research questions
- Chapter 6 concludes and outlines implications for policy and future research

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 THEORETICAL FOUNDATIONS

2.1.1 POST DISASTER DISPLACEMENT THEORY

Displacement theory in the aftermath of a climate change disaster, such as Cyclone Idai, has evolved from a "maximalist" perspective which viewed the environment as the sole driver of movement to a complex, multi-causal framework emphasizing social vulnerability, adaptive capacity, and translocal realities (Mosneaga and Jacobs, 2022).

The following sections outline theoretical components that are central to contemporary displacement theory and particularly relevant in the case of Cyclone Idai displacement.

2.1.1.1 Protection Motivation Theory (PMT)

PMT is a leading behavioral framework used to understand why individuals choose to stay or migrate after a disaster (Duijndam et. al., 2025). It consists of two primary cognitive processes:

- **Threat Appraisal:** How an individual perceives the likelihood, severity, and emotional worry associated with a disaster. Following Cyclone Idai, residents in Mozambique showed that high levels of "flood worry" were strongly associated with higher intentions to migrate permanently (Duijndam et. al., 2025).
- **Coping Appraisal:** This involves self-efficacy (belief in one's ability to migrate), response efficacy (the perceived effectiveness of migration in reducing risk), and migration costs. In lower-income contexts like Mozambique, high migration costs often act as a significant deterrent, even when the threat is high (Duijndam et. al., 2025).

2.1.1.2 The Vulnerability and Heuristic Framework

Modern theory argues that disasters are not purely "natural" but are social constructs (Wolde et. al., 2023). Displacement is driven by a "cascading flow" of three interconnected orbits:

- **Underlying Non-Environmental Drivers:** Factors such as poor infrastructure, high unemployment, corruption, and lack of government preparedness create the initial state of vulnerability (Wolde et. al., 2023).
- **Indirect Drivers (Accumulated Change):** Slow-onset issues like land degradation, soil infertility, and food insecurity that weaken a community's resilience over time (Wolde et. al., 2023).
- **Direct Drivers (Extreme Events):** Sudden events like cyclones and floods (as in Cyclone Idai) that act as the final "push" for immediate displacement (Wolde et. al., 2023).

2.1.1.3 The Migration-Displacement Continuum (Adaptation vs. Loss and Damage)

Theoretical debates now distinguish between movement as a proactive choice versus a forced outcome:

- **Migration as Adaptation:** Viewed as a proactive, resilient strategy where individuals move (often circularly or temporarily) to diversify income and cope with environmental stress (Mosneaga and Jacobs 2022).

- **Displacement as Loss and Damage:** Viewed as a failure of adaptation. It represents the "residual costs" that could not be avoided. The case of Cyclone Idai highlights that displacement often leads to non-economic losses, such as the destruction of social networks, cultural heritage, and mental well-being, which are difficult to quantify (Mosneaga and Jacobs 2022).

2.1.1.4 The Translocal Lens

This theory challenges the traditional international-national binary by focusing on lived realities at the local level. It examines how local encounters with transnational legal norms and government policies shape mobility (Mosneaga and Jacobs 2022).

In Mozambique, following Cyclone Idai, the national government prioritized resettlement (framed as a "climate solution"), while local municipal authorities and residents often resisted because the new sites lacked urban job opportunities and social services (DTM reports, 2019, 2020). This lens reveals the power dynamics and "top-down" interventions that may ignore the heterogeneous needs of a displaced population. Zimbabwe on the other hand exhibited weak institutional intervention as well as social capital, resulting in unorganised and family scale type of movements (Musnaka et al., 2021).

2.1.1.5 Trapped Populations and Immobility

Displacement theory now recognizes that the most vulnerable individuals are often the least mobile (Chigudu, 2025). "Trapped populations" are those who face extreme environmental risks but lack the financial or social capital required to relocate. Following Idai, many remained in high-risk areas because they could not afford to commute from rural resettlement sites to urban centers where their livelihoods remained.

2.1.2 Frameworks on Climate Disaster Displacement

The mobility of internally displaced persons (IDPs) affected by climate disasters in Zimbabwe (Giorgi et. al., 2014) and Mozambique is governed by a multi-layered framework of international principles, regional treaties, and evolving national laws. Both countries are signatories to the Kampala Convention, which is the primary regional legal instrument for IDP protection in Africa.

2.1.2.1 International Frameworks

While no single universally binding treaty exists solely for IDPs, several international frameworks provide normative guidance:

- **UN Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement (1998):** These provide the standard descriptive definition of IDPs, explicitly including those forced to flee due to natural or human-made disasters (Onuk et. al., 2023). Principle 6 protects individuals from being arbitrarily displaced from their homes, including in cases of disaster unless the safety and health of those affected require evacuation.
- **Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction (2015–2030):** This global agreement focuses on reducing disaster risks and "building back better" during recovery, which includes managing displacement and human mobility in the context of climate shocks (African Union, 2021).

- **International Human Rights and Humanitarian Law:** Instruments such as the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR) and International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (ICESCR) guarantee fundamental rights that remain applicable during displacement, including freedom of movement, the right to food, and the right to adequate shelter (Ahmad, 2017).

2.1.2.2 Regional Regulations

The primary regional governing bodies and treaties include:

- **The Kampala Convention (2009):** Zimbabwe ratified this in 2013, and Mozambique ratified it in 2017/2020. It is the first legally binding continental treaty requiring states to protect and assist persons displaced by natural disasters and climate change. Article 12(3) specifically makes a state party liable to compensate IDPs for damage if the state refrains from protecting them during a natural disaster (Global Protection Cluster, Task Team on Law and Policy, 2022).
- **Great Lakes IDP Protocol (2006):** Zimbabwe is a "co-opted member" and has participated in negotiations for this protocol, which requires member states to mitigate the consequences of displacement caused by natural disasters (Giorgi et. al., 2014).
- **SADC Disaster Risk Management Strategy:** Both countries are members of the Southern African Development Community, which prioritizes contingency planning and regional coordination for disaster-induced mobility (Giorgi et. al., 2014).

2.1.2.3 National Regulations in Zimbabwe

Zimbabwe's legal framework is currently in a state of transition regarding IDP rights (Giorgi et. al., 2014):

- **The 2013 Constitution:** This is the supreme law and provides broad protections, including the right to freedom of movement and residence (Section 66) and freedom from arbitrary eviction (Section 74). However, it does not yet contain a specific definition or formal recognition of "internal displacement".
- **Civil Protection Act (1989):** This is the primary law for disaster management and establishes the Civil Protection Unit. It focuses on disaster response and relief rather than long-term hazard mitigation or IDP-specific rights.
- **Domestication Status:** Although Zimbabwe has ratified the Kampala Convention, it has not yet passed implementing legislation to formally incorporate the treaty's provisions into domestic law.

2.1.2.4 National Regulations in Mozambique

Mozambique has recently established more specific policies to manage disaster-related mobility:

- **Policy and Strategy for Internal Displacement Management (PEGDI) (2021):** Adopted through Council of Ministers Resolution No. 42/2021, this policy explicitly aligns national efforts with the Kampala Convention (IOM, 2025). It addresses prevention, assistance during displacement, and durable solutions for those affected by both conflict and climate disasters.
- **Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Law (Law 10/2020):** This updated legislative framework provides the basis for disaster risk management and is

complemented by Decree 76/2020, which outlines procedures for application (IDRL, 2023).

- **National Adaptation Plan (NAP) (2023):** This plan identifies climate change as a major driver of displacement and recognizes planned relocation as a legitimate adaptation strategy (IOM, 2025).
- **Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC 3.0):** Mozambique is currently working to integrate human mobility, including migration and displacement, directly into its climate commitments to build resilience against loss and damage (IOM, 2025).

2.1.2.5 Synthesis of Regulatory Differences

The primary difference lies in the level of formal integration of IDP rights into national law:

- **Domestication of the Kampala Convention:** Mozambique has taken more concrete steps toward domestication, adopting the Policy and Strategy for Internal Displacement Management (PEGDI) in 2021 to align national efforts with the Convention (IOM, 2025). Zimbabwe ratified the Convention in 2013 but has not yet passed implementing legislation, meaning its provisions do not formally part of domestic law (giorgi et. al., 2014).
- **Legislative Focus:** Zimbabwe relies on the Civil Protection Act of 1989, which is criticized for being reactive and relief-oriented rather than proactive or mitigation-focused (Chirisa, 2021). In contrast, Mozambique updated its legal regime with the Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Law (Law 10/2020) and explicitly recognizes planned relocation as a legitimate climate adaptation strategy (IDRL, 2023).
- **Institutional Framework:** Mozambique established the National Institute for Disaster Risk Management and Reduction (INGD) as a specialized body with financial and technical autonomy (IDRL, 2023). Zimbabwe lacks a designated authority for IDP issues, unofficially splitting responsibilities between the Civil Protection Unit and the Ministry of Social Welfare, which often lack the specialized mandate or resources to handle long-term displacement (Giorgi, 2014).
- **Adherence to Governing Frameworks:** According to the African Union Report (2020) Mozambique was notably successful in early warning systems with collaboration between disaster authorities, the Red Cross and local structures, while Zimbabwe experienced a lack of coordination and communication at community level in the areas at high displacement risk. Additionally, the Zimbabwe government had no expedited legal mechanisms to replace legal documentation lost in the cyclone resulting in a risk of statelessness among the Chimanimani and Chipinge IDPs (Giorgio et. at., 2014). While Mozambique adhered to its relocation strategies, Zimbabwe adhered to the reactive relief model as the National Civil Protection Fund was under-resourced.

2.2 POST DISASTER MOVEMENTS AND IMMOBILITY

The types of disaster induced mobility can be classified as below:

2.2.1 Relocation

A state-led process where persons or groups are assisted to move away from homes or temporary residences to a new location provided with the conditions for rebuilding their lives (Mbiyozo, 2021). It is typically a "last resort" for places that have become uninhabitable due to slow-onset impacts like desertification or sudden-onset disasters like floods.

2.2.2 Resettlement

While often used interchangeably with relocation, resettlement is generally broader, implying the restoration of entire communities and their socio-economic conditions (Mosneaga and Jacobs, 2022). In Mozambique, the government specifically uses the term *reassentamento* to describe the organized movement of people from high-risk flood zones to permanent sites.

2.2.3 Return

This occurs when displaced or relocated individuals move back to their original, often risk-prone, homes (Ncube and Murray, 2025). This is frequently driven by a dependency on original farmlands for livelihoods or a lack of alternative income in relocation sites.

2.2.4 Immobility

This refers to "spatial continuity in an individual's centre of gravity over a period of time" (Ncube and Murray, 2025).

- Voluntary Immobility: Staying by choice, often due to strong place attachment or existing coping strategies (Duijndam et. al., 2025).
- Involuntary Immobility (Trapped Populations): Remaining in high-risk areas because of a lack of financial resources or physical capability to move (Duijndam et. al., 2025)..
- Negotiated (Im)mobility: A newly conceptualized state of agency where households manage two locations utilizing government-provided housing for safety while returning to original flood-prone lands for agricultural activities (Ncube and Murray, 2025).

2.3 ACTOR MECHANISMS ON POST-IDAI MOBILITY

2.3.1 State

In both Zimbabwe and Mozambique, the government's primary strategy for mobility involved state-led planned relocation from high-risk zones to permanent resettlement sites. In Zimbabwe, the response was highly militarized, with the Civil Protection Unit (CPU) relying on the Zimbabwe National Army and Air Force for search, rescue, and the airlifting of supplies to inaccessible areas (Nyahunda et. al., 2022). In Mozambique, the National Institute for Disaster Management (INGC) rapidly established 66 resettlement sites within months, moving approximately 80,000 people to safer ground. However, these government-led processes were often criticized for being top-down and lacking adequate consultation with the displaced populations regarding their new locations (Jacobs and Almeida, 2020).

2.3.2 Third Sector (Humanitarian Actors)

These actors provided the logistical and material backbone of the response, filling gaps in under-resourced government systems. They managed temporary accommodation centers, registered displaced persons, and provided "lifesaving" aid, including food, tents, water purification, and psychosocial support (Nyahunda et. al., 2022). In resettlement sites like Mutua in Mozambique, humanitarian organizations like the IOM and various other UN agencies provided the initial infrastructure, such as health tents and public latrines (Jacobs and Almeida, 2020).

2.3.3 Community

Local residents were the primary first responders, often pulling neighbors from the rubble and providing initial food and shelter before any external aid arrived (Munsaka et. al., 2021). Regarding mobility, many community members engaged in survival-based migration, for instance, some residents in Beira's Praia Nova neighborhood returned to high-risk areas because they lacked urban alternatives or needed to maintain proximity to their informal jobs (Kadungure, 2025). Others in rural areas like Muzarabani adopted cyclical migration patterns, moving to riverbanks for cultivation during dry seasons and returning to original villages when floods hit.

2.3.4 Cross Actor dynamics

2.3.4.1 State and Third sector

There is a general consensus that the success of this interaction depends on state effectiveness, meaning, there is willingness of African governments to shape and deliver the change they require themselves (Leigh, 2013). In cases of cooperation, humanitarian interventions should be in sync and guided by receiving governments, centring recipient needs and maintaining the sovereignty of the state. Since history, a fraught relationship between humanitarian actors and religious missionaries poses problems for the resettlement sites (Everil, 2013).

A long standing problem in this dynamic has been that donors are accountable to aid recipients and the tax payers of their home country, which Alan Hudson and Paolo de Renzio (2011) have called 'impossible geometries of aid.' In a bid to ease the bureaucratic and complicated interaction with the local state, there is often a straight-to-citizen output. This process has been criticised as perpetuating the "White Man's Burden" narrative (Leigh, 2013). Moreover, humanitarian need is often urgent and therefore addresses short term

relief needs that are not sustainable long term. Therefore, while effective aid includes supporting the government to be effective, the time constraints and complicated nature of official processes make it easier for the state, recipients, donors and their taxpayers to continue the short sighted aid processes that emasculate local governments.

In the Idai case Interaction was often "frosty," particularly in Zimbabwe, where the government viewed many NGOs with suspicion, perceiving them as agents for political change. This led to rigorous vetting processes and bureaucratic delays that stymied the delivery of aid to victims. Furthermore, the government required that many NGO donations be channeled through the military-led Civil Protection Unit, which limited the autonomy of humanitarian actors.

2.3.4.2 Government and Community

In Zimbabwe, the interaction involved traditional leaders who assisted in aid distribution, though this was frequently marred by the politicization of aid, where individuals perceived as opposition supporters were allegedly denied assistance (Nyahunda et. al., 2022). In Mozambique, residents felt the government used a "technical" solution of resettlement that ignored their urban livelihood needs, leading to the perception that they were being moved to "the bush" for political reasons (Jacobs and Almeida, 2020).

2.3.4.3 Third Sector and Community

While NGOs provided critical relief, their focus on registered "displaced" persons sometimes created friction with host communities (Munsaka et. al., 2021). Local villagers who were not directly displaced but used their own limited resources to help survivors felt neglected and "unfairly treated" when they were excluded from external donor aid (Nyahunda et. al., 2022).

2.3.4.5 Inter-Agency Coordination

A significant challenge was the lack of coordination among humanitarian organizations themselves, which led to a "haphazard" delivery of services, the duplication of efforts in some areas, and the total neglect of others, particularly regarding mental health and psychosocial support (Nyahunda et. al., 2022).

2.4 DIGITAL METHODS IN RESEARCH

In the context of research regarding a disaster like Cyclone Idai and media reporting on mobility, digital methods represent an epistemology and set of techniques that repurpose the technical and discursive affordances of the internet such as digital artifacts, to study social and cultural processes (Rogers, 2013). Instead of relying solely on traditional surveys, these methods leverage the "digital footprint" left by individuals and organizations online to uncover patterns of behavior, discourse, and movement (Blazquez and Domenech, 2018).

2.4.1 Use of Digital News and Social Media in Research

In socio-economic and disaster-related research, digital news media and social media serve several critical functions:

- **Social Media as "Human Sensors":** Platforms like Youtube (particularly discourse in the comments) are recognized as real-time, topic-driven forums suitable for detecting trends and exploring discourse dynamics during crises. They allow researchers to monitor human societal-scale behavior and beliefs globally (Carneiro et. al., 2022). Specifically for mobility, social media can act as a proxy for identifying anomalous behavioral patterns associated with emergency events.
- **Digital News as Official Narrative:** Corporate and government websites provide a "business-generated" or institutional perspective, reflecting official responses, policy shifts, and public image management during and after a disaster (Blazquez and Domenech, 2018).
- **Mobility Pattern Detection:** Research can utilize mobile sensors (GPS, GSM, and Call Detail Records) to study how human mobility affects social organization at the macro level. These data sources help recreate maps of population distribution and detect how move-related behaviors change during emergencies (Blazquez and Domenech, 2018).

2.4.2 Justification for Using Digital Data and Methods

The use of these non-traditional data sources is justified by several factors identified in the sources:

- **The "Data Big Bang":** The exponential growth of digitized data provides a stream of fresh, massive, and updated information that traditional official records cannot match in terms of velocity and volume (Rogers, 2013).
- **Capturing "Soft" Influence:** Traditional metrics often fail to capture less explicit forms of influence, such as how science or media shape public opinion and policy agendas (Carneiro et. al., 2022). Digital methods can reveal "below the surface" impacts, such as changes in culture, attitude, and network connectivity.
- **Real-time Monitoring and Nowcasting:** These methods allow for "nowcasting," that is, predicting the present state of a variable, in this case mobility or unemployment, more precisely and faster than traditional statistical models (Blazquez and Domenech, 2018).

2.4.3 Mapping Against Quantitative Data

In this type of research, digital (often unstructured) data is increasingly mapped against or integrated with quantitative data to enhance predictive power and insight:

- **Structuring Unstructured Text:** Techniques such as text mining and Natural Language Processing (NLP) are used to transform unstructured media reports into structured, normalized data (Carneiro et. al., 2022). This allows narrative information to be quantified and analyzed using statistical tools (Carneiro et. al., 2025).

- **Machine Learning (ML) Integration:** Researchers apply ML models to determine the most important predictors of an outcome (such as food insecurity or displacement) by using these "text-derived features" alongside traditional quantitative indicators like market prices, rainfall data, or demographic statistics (Carneiro et. al., 2025).
- **Validation and Correlation:** Findings from digital sources are validated by correlating them with established quantitative datasets, such as the World Development Indicators (WDI), to ensure the digital traces accurately reflect real-world socio-economic conditions (Carneiro et. al., 2025).
- **Mixed Methods Frameworks:** Comprehensive studies often combine Social Network Analysis (SNA) to map actors and information flows with traditional bibliometric or econometric data to provide a holistic view of a disaster's reach and the subsequent recovery efforts (Carneiro et. al., 2022).

2.5 RESEARCH GAPS

Contemporary scholarship on disaster mobility has advanced beyond single-factor explanations to emphasise multi-causal processes that combine hazard exposure, social vulnerability, and institutional responses. Yet several empirical and methodological gaps remain.

First, immobility is understudied: many displaced populations remain in place for prolonged periods and are under-represented in policy and research (Gemenne, 2021, Fekete, 2025).

Second, return is often analysed as a binary outcome rather than a heterogeneous process that can be temporary, assisted, or coerced.

Third, there is a lack of comparative studies that systematically examine how different governance frameworks and humanitarian modalities produce divergent mobility trajectories. Additional gaps include data classification and quality issues (high shares of unclassified sites), temporal mismatches between monitoring systems and public narratives, language and platform biases in digital methods, a governance implementation gap between legal ratification and practice, and intersectional blind spots that obscure the experiences of the most vulnerable.

Addressing these gaps requires mixed-methods designs that combine longitudinal site-level monitoring, multilingual text analysis, and purposive qualitative follow-up present in this thesis to triangulate IDM data, media discourse, and third-sector reporting.

3.0 METHODOLOGY

The research aims to investigate how the interactions of state, humanitarian and community dynamics shaped post disaster mobility after cyclone Idai. The study therefore adopts a pragmatist research philosophy, which allows for the integration of multiple methods to address complex phenomena such as this one.

The research recognises both data-driven representations and descriptions of displacement presented in site reports and the socially constructed narratives in the media, both official and expressed on social media by individuals and institutional actors. Through econometric analysis, patterns and causes are established, while there is also interpretation of texts to seek meaning and power dynamics at play.

Through traditional quantitative methods, we draw interpretations of existing frameworks, while the Digital Methods approach allows for new relevant themes to emerge from the data.

3.1 RESEARCH DESIGN

The research employs a mixed-methods, comparative design in two dimensions:

- a) **Country-level comparison** of mobility dynamics following Cyclone Idai in Zimbabwe and Mozambique.
- b) **Actor-level comparison** assessing how state agencies, third-sector organisations, and community actors interact to shape mobility outcomes, both within each country and comparatively between them.

The mixed-study triangulates multiple sources combining:

- Quantitative econometric analysis of displacement datasets
- Digital Methods to examine public narratives in news, social media and humanitarian reports
- Qualitative Text Analysis of the extracted social media, humanitarian reports and news articles

3.2 DATA COLLECTION METHODS

3.2.1 Quantitative Data

Secondary data was collected from IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) Site Assessment Round Reports for Mozambique and Zimbabwe from March 2019 to November 2021 (the period related to cyclone Idai). The datasets contain information on the displacement patterns, return movements, relocation, resettlement processes and immobile populations.

3.2.2 Digital methods

Information was scraped from various sources by different tools to analyse media coverage and social media discourse. Sources are divided into news, social media and humanitarian reports.

Tools : YouTube data Tools¹, Media Cloud², direct duplication

News Sources : Local and international news outlets

Social Media Sources : Youtube

Humanitarian Reporting: ReliefWeb³

3.3 SAMPLING STRATEGY

3.3.1 Quantitative Data Sampling

In all the available IOM site reports used, a census approach is used, which adheres to the criteria useful for the study:

- geographic relevance to the sites affected by the cyclone (Mozambique and Zimbabwe)
- availability of mobility indicators
- comparability between the countries
- capturing the mobility trajectories over time through multiple rounds

3.3.2 Media and Reports Sampling

News article Criteria

- Title must Include “Idai”
- Dates between 1 March 2019 - 31 March 2020
- Collections : Cabo Verde - National, Equatorial Guinea - National, Guinea-Bissau - National, Portugal - National, Portugal - State & Local, Sao Tome and Principe - National, Global English Language Sources, Angola - National, Maputo, Mozambique - State & Local, Mozambique - National, Mozambique - State & Local, Zambezia, Mozambique - State & Local, Bulawayo, Zimbabwe - State & Local, Harare, Zimbabwe - State & Local, Manicaland, Zimbabwe - State & Local, Mashonaland West, Zimbabwe - State & Local, Masvingo, Zimbabwe - State & Local, Midlands, Zimbabwe - State & Local, Zimbabwe - National, Zimbabwe - State & Local
- Language : English and Portuguese

¹ <https://ytdt.digitalmethods.net/index.php>

² <https://search.mediacloud.org/>

³ <https://reliefweb.int/>

Social media Criteria

- Posts : Top 500 posts relevant to search query “cyclone idai”
- Comments : to 10 most engaged videos under search query “cyclone idai”

Humanitarian Reports/ Articles

- Search query “Cyclone Idai”
- Article Title must include “Cyclone Idai”
- Article referencing particularly “Mozambique and / or Zimbabwe”

3.4 DATA ANALYSIS METHODS

3.4.1 Quantitative Data Analysis

The International Organization for Migration (IOM) Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) datasets were processed using Stata (Version 19.5). The analysis followed a structured workflow to ensure cross-country comparability:

- **Data Cleaning and Harmonization:** The raw baseline datasets for Mozambique and Zimbabwe were merged into a single longitudinal panel. Variables were standardized to account for differences in reporting frequencies (averaging 71 observations/month in Mozambique vs. 55 in Zimbabwe).
- **Aggregation and Descriptive Statistics:** Data was aggregated at the site and country levels to calculate "Average IDP Population per Site" and "Return Rates."
- **Volatility and Mobility Modeling:** To measure the stability of post-disaster movement, a **volatility metric** was created by calculating the relative change in site population between reporting rounds.
- **Visualizations:** Stata was utilized to generate distribution histograms (identifying "heavy tails" or outliers in movement), scatter plots (mapping size vs. variation), and comparative line graphs to track recovery trajectories over time.

3.4.2 News and Social Media Data Analysis

To analyze large-scale text data from news outlets and YouTube, Openrefine, Orange3, Youtube Data tools and 4CAT were used. This allowed for a visual programming approach to Natural Language Processing (NLP):

- **Data Cleaning:** The raw news data from Media Cloud were cleaned and transformed for processing through OpenRefine (Version 3.10.0)⁴ for clean text extraction and Python (Version 3.14.4)⁵ to separate articles as per language.
- **Text Pre-processing:** News articles and social media comments underwent tokenization, normalization, and stopword removal to eliminate "noise" (e.g., "cyclone," "Idai," and common conjunctions).

⁴ <https://openrefine.org/>

⁵ <https://www.python.org/>

- **Sentiment Analysis:** A sentiment scoring algorithm VADER within Orange3 (version 3.40.0)⁶ was applied to the news corpus to quantify the "emotional temperature" of reporting in both English and Portuguese. For the social media comments, 4CAT⁷ was used to assign sentiment scores to the comments.
- **Temporal Analysis:** Sentiment scores were plotted against a time-series axis using 4CAT to identify specific "narrative peaks" or periods of negative consistent reporting (notably at the 6-month mark).
- **Social Media Mining:** For the YouTube data, Youtube Data Tools was used to extract the text and dates, and Orange to cluster the most frequent descriptors, which were then visualized via Word Clouds to represent the "community voice."

3.4.3 Third Sector Corpus Analysis

The 41 humanitarian reports and situation updates sourced from ReliefWeb⁸ were analyzed using Voyant Tools⁹, an open-source, web-based environment for corpus linguistics. This tool was selected for its "forensic" text capabilities:

- **Collocation and Link Analysis:** The "Links" tool was used to visualize the conceptual proximity between "Government," "Humanitarian Actors," and "IDPs." This revealed how different actors were framed in relation to one another.
- **Keyword in Context (KWIC):** The "Contexts" tool was used to examine the specific linguistic framing of "Return" and "Resettlement," allowing the researcher to distinguish between "mandated" pathways and "observed" outcomes.
- **Corpus Summary:** Global trends in word frequency were used to compare the thematic weight given to "Humanitarian Response" versus "Governance Frameworks."

3.4.4 Data Triangulation and Integration

The final stage of analysis involved concurrent triangulation. Patterns identified in the Stata volatility models (quantitative) were cross-referenced with the sentiment shifts in Orange and the thematic priorities in Voyant (qualitative). This allowed the study to identify "friction points" such as instances where official humanitarian "return" narratives (Voyant) diverged from the actual population fluctuations (Stata) and community sentiment (Orange).

⁶ <https://orangedatamining.com/>

⁷ <https://4cat.nl/>

⁸ <https://reliefweb.int/>

⁹ <https://voyant-tools.org/>

3.5 LIMITATIONS AND ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

3.5.1 Limitations

Data Gaps : The displacement datasets available are, to a lesser extent, not complete and contain inconsistent criteria in reporting considering the rapidity of contextual evolution post disaster. The number of rounds and collection criteria are not identical between Zimbabwe and Mozambique. (See Table 3.6 in Appendices for numerical breakdown of missing data)

Digital Divide : Social media data may not fully represent public sentiment, particularly of the affected communities due to the digital divide and access during the disaster period.

Bias : Media discourse may contain editorial framing or politically biased reporting on how mobility is discussed.

3.5.2 Ethical Considerations

The study heavily relies on secondary data and publicly accessible sources.

However, where community perspectives are discussed, the research aims to avoid misrepresentation by contextualising data within broader empirical findings.

For reproducibility, all codes and queries used in the analysis tools are archived (links in appendices).

4.0 RESULTS

4.1 BASELINE CONTEXT AND MOBILITY PATTERNS

Table 4.1 Reporting Synthesis - IDM baseline reports

Country	min	max	count	Active Months	Average Observations per Month
Mozambique	3/17/2019	10/1/2021	1348	19	70.94736842
Zimbabwe	6/4/2019	12/11/2021	1210	22	55

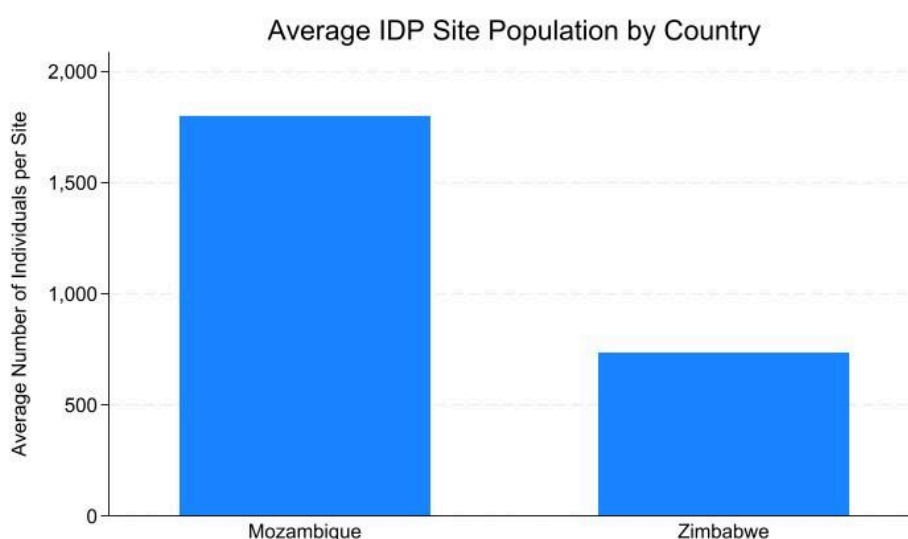
The quantitative results are based on the baseline datasets from the IOM's Internal Displacement Matrix (IDM) database with data collected from the affected sites following Cyclone Idai. As shown in Table 4.1, while Mozambique was captured with high temporal resolution at an average of 71 observations per month, the Zimbabwean records stretch for three more months. These records are comparable and allow for more acute transition in Mozambique and better resettlement observation in Zimbabwe.

4.1.1 SCALE

This section examines the foundational stage of the post-Cyclone Idai response, focusing on how national governance frameworks established the mandated pathways for displaced populations and the subsequent scale of the crisis in terms of the IDPs. In mixed-methods research, the initial categorization of a crisis often dictates the scale and shape of the physical response (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2018).

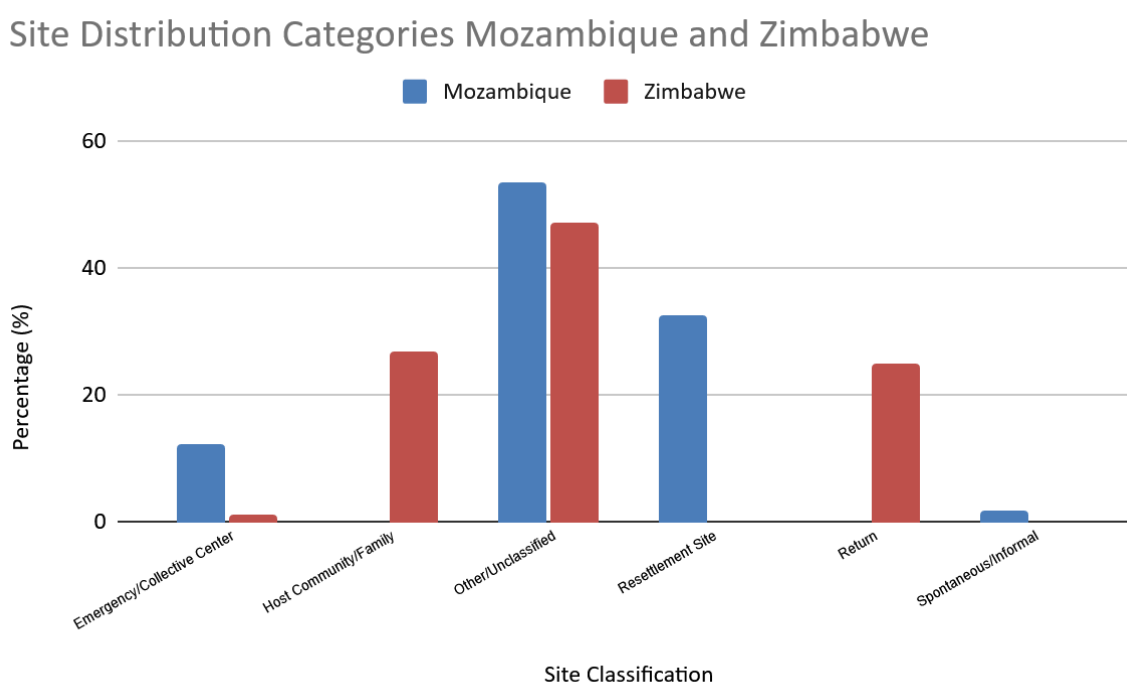
In terms of scale, Figure 4.1.1.1 shows that Mozambique's IDP sites are, on average, substantially larger than those in Zimbabwe.

Figure 4.1.1.1 Bar Graph showing Average IDP Population per Site per Country



The categorisations of these sites also differ per the country reports as shown in Figure 4.1.1.2 (refer to Table 4.1.1 in appendices for full numeric breakdowns) below. While both countries have a significant proportion that is unclassified throughout the data timeline, including sites that changed categories, Zimbabwe contains Host Community and Return categories that do not exist in Mozambique. Mozambique has a significantly higher percentage of sites categorised as emergency in comparison to Zimbabwe. It is clear that the largest proportion of sites in both countries are unclassified or unknown. For the labelled sites, the most evident differences across countries are between a high percentage of community hosting in Zimbabwe and a high proportion of Resettlement sites in Mozambique.

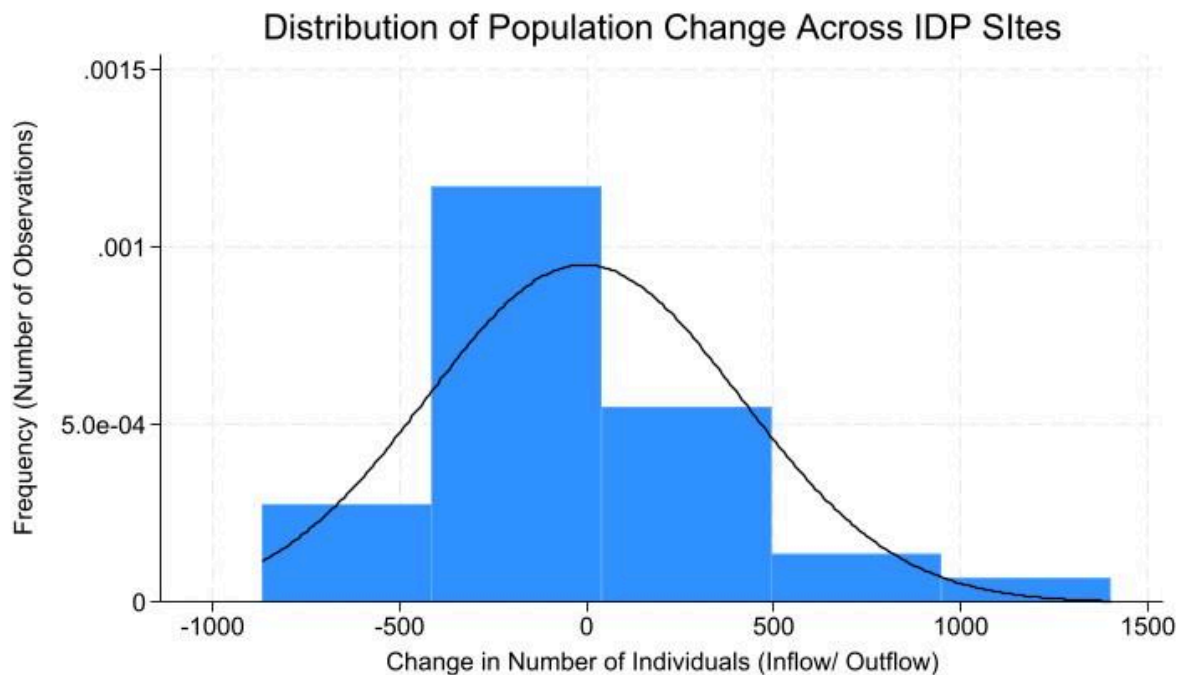
Fig 4.1.1.2 Comparative Bar Graph Site Distribution Categories per Country



4.1.2 DYNAMICS

Considering the chaotic nature of disasters and consequent movement of people, this section illustrates volatility through econometric data. Volatility is defined here as the degree of fluctuation in individual counts between reporting periods. The emergency phase is tested through volatility evidenced from recorded physical movements, both collectively and comparatively between the countries in study.

Figure 4.1.2.1 Bar Graph showing Overall Distribution of of Population Change Across IDP Sites

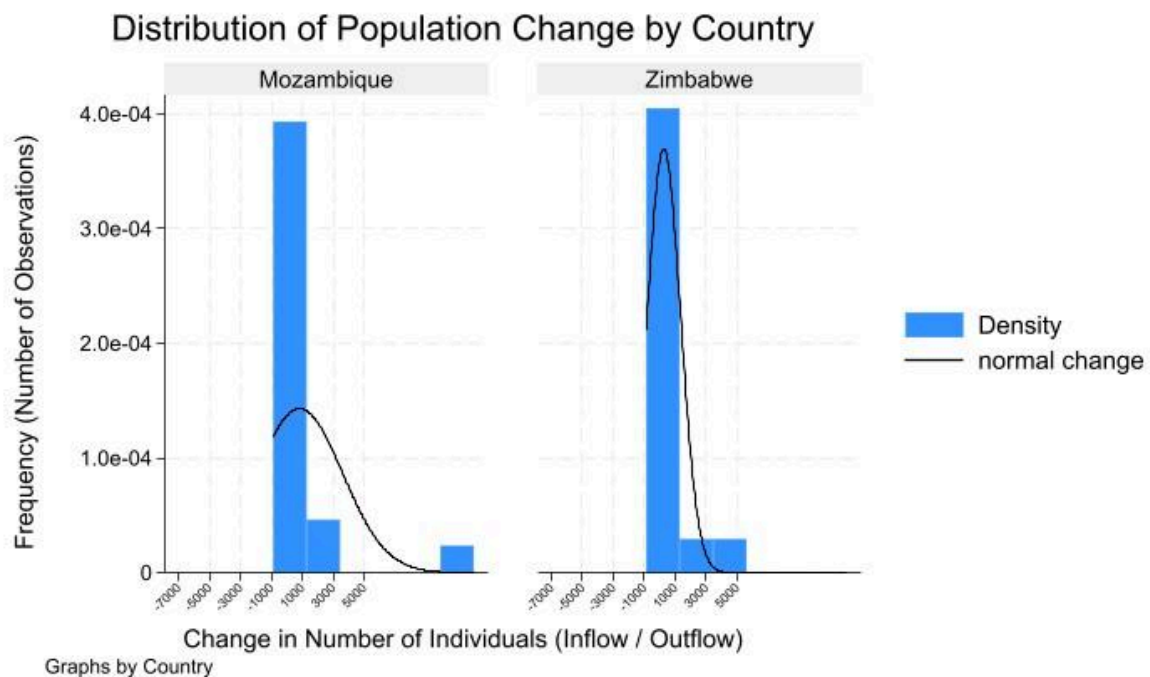


The distribution of population change across IDP sites reveals highly variable mobility dynamics across both countries, the variable spectrum of post disaster mobility. Before moving to the rate of change, the distribution illustrates the magnitude at which the change happened. The data, as shown in Fig.4.1.2.1, shows a high concentration of observations around the zero-point and a longer right tail. The negative indicates outflow while positive indicates inflow, the wide range indicating varying scales and localisations of movement. However, the heavy tails of the histogram reveal significant outliers:

- **Negative Outliers:** Represent rapid site de-congestions or sudden evacuations (outflux).
- **Positive Outliers:** Represent rapid influxes or the sudden establishment of new "Accommodation Centers."

The presence of these extremes confirms that the post-Idai environment was characterized by volatile mobility where specific geographic nodes experienced massive population shifts in very short timeframes, despite the overall regional average remaining lower.

Figure 4.1.2.2 Bar Graph showing Overall Distribution of of Population Change Across IDP Sites per country



As shown in Fig. 4.1.2.2, Mozambique has a wider spread of values, the right long tail exhibiting the more extreme extent. This volatility is shown to be more significant in Fig. 4.1.2.3 below which visualises the volatility on average for both countries. While Mozambique shows more variation overall, Zimbabwe also has extreme but fewer extreme changes. It has a tightly clustered distribution mostly around zero.

Figure 4.2.1.3

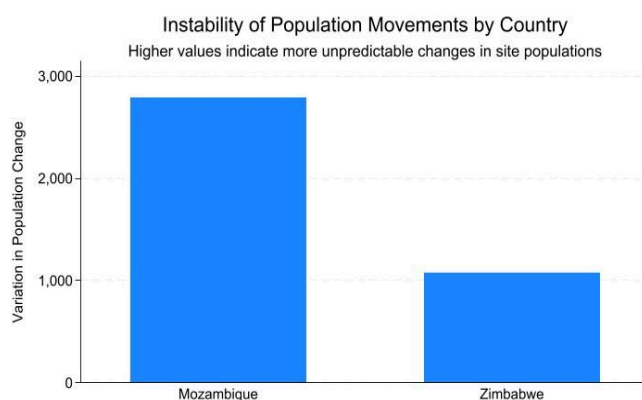
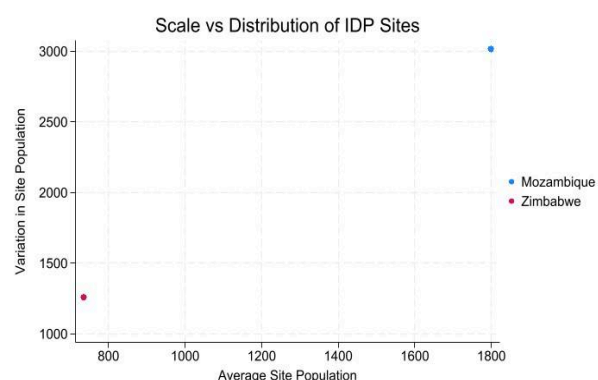


Figure 4.2.1.3

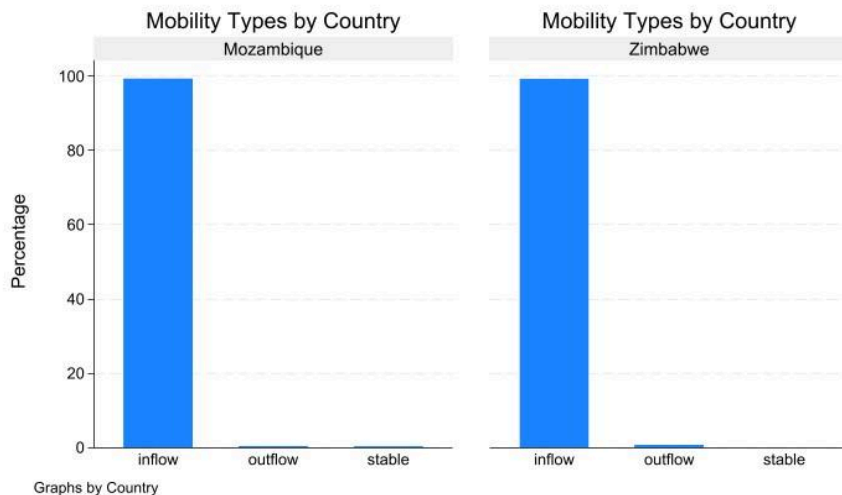


The relationship between average site size and variation (Fig 4.1.2.4) further shows the differences. Mozambique combines large site sizes with high variability, while Zimbabwe, by contrast, exhibits smaller and more uniform site distributions.

4.1.3 OUTCOMES

Having seen the patterns of stability or lack of, this section aims to demonstrate the types of mobility that emerged as these are key in representing the stability of the IDPs post disaster and also indicating the inflows, outflow and stable proportions of the overall movement.

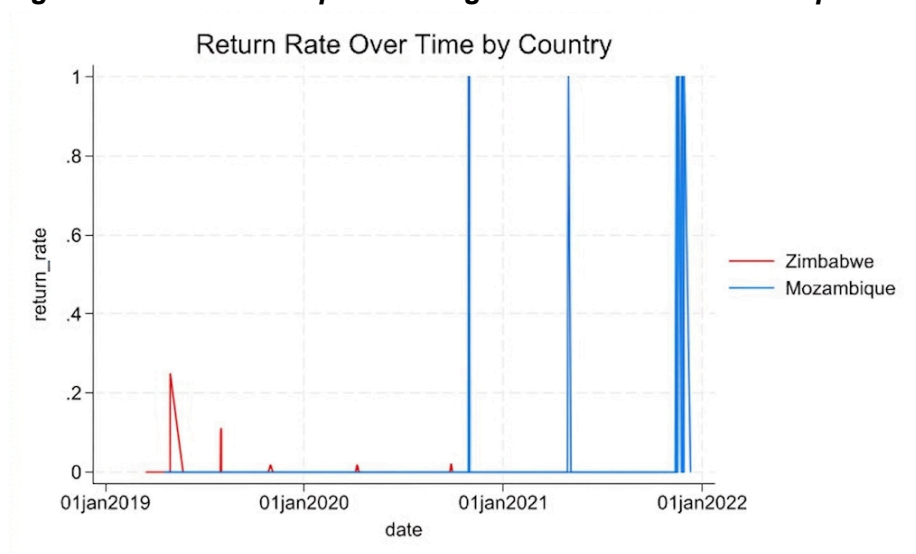
Figure 4.1.3.1 Bar Graph showing Mobility Types by Country



The comparative graphs in Fig. 4.1.3.1 (refer to Table 4.1.3 in appendices for full numeric breakdowns) show that both countries have comparable patterns of mobility. Both have extreme inflow movements and low outflow with Mozambique additionally exhibiting a percentage of stable movement absent in Zimbabwe.

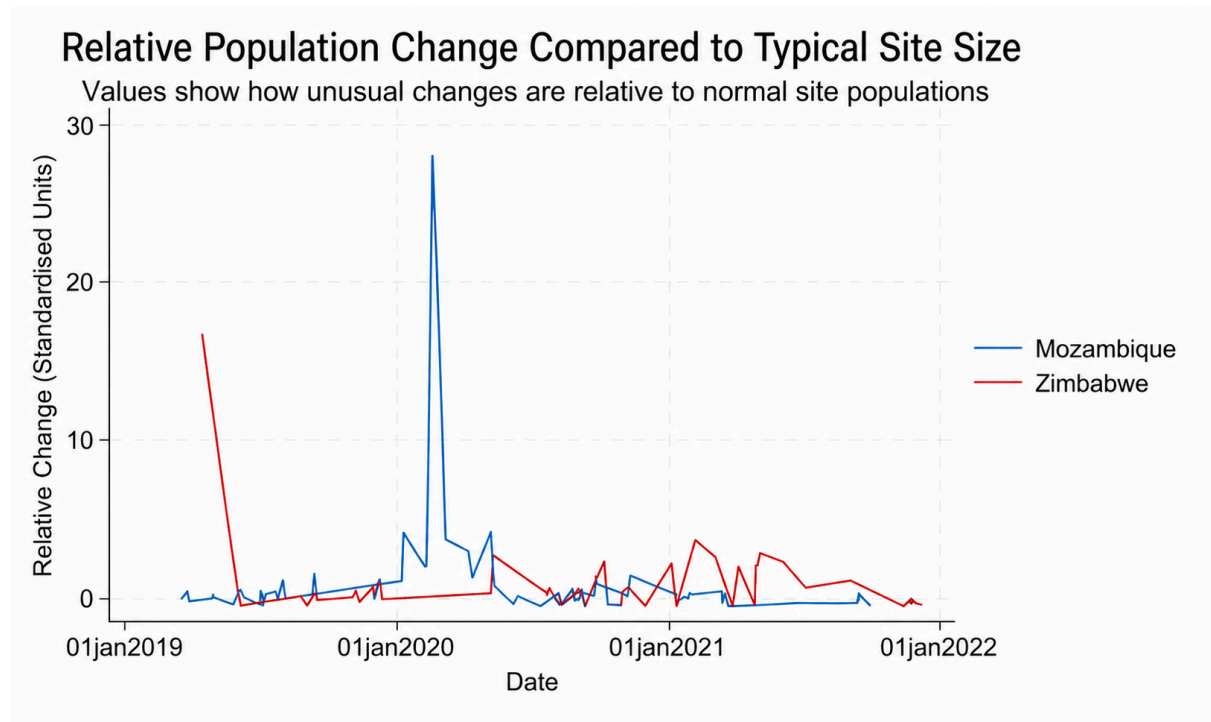
The return rate shown in Fig. 4.1.3.2 indicates differing recovery trajectories. Mozambique shows periods of significant return activity following initial displacement peaks, whereas Zimbabwe's return patterns appear more gradual and less pronounced.

Figure 4.1.3.2 Line Graph showing Return Rate Over Time per country



Of interest is how the relative average population change per site (see 4.1.3.3 below) changes differently per country and across the timeline.

Figure 4.1.3.3 Line Graph showing Relative Population Change Compared to Typical Site Size over time



Mozambique exhibits sharper and more frequent fluctuations, whereas Zimbabwe demonstrates more subdued and stable patterns over time.

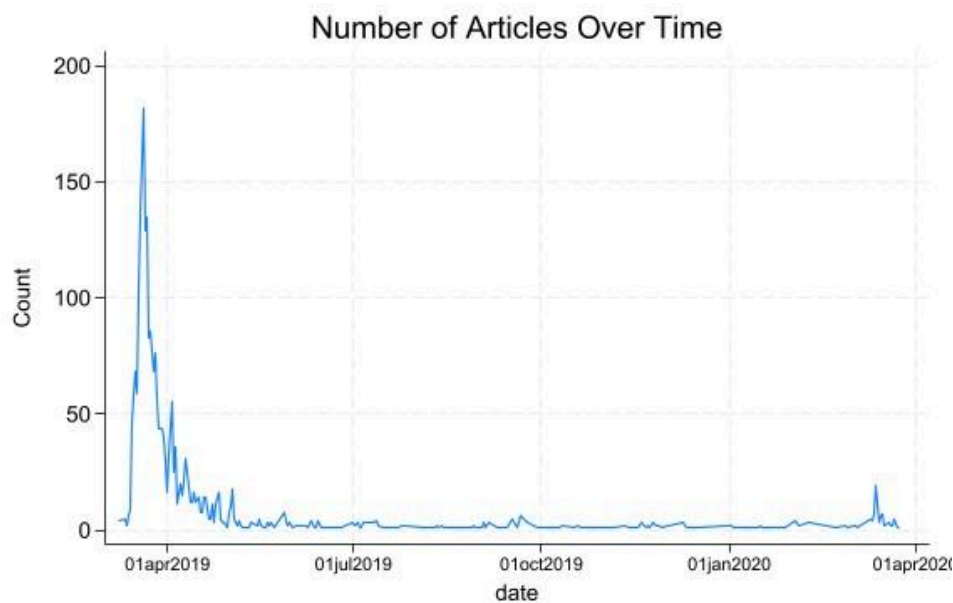
4.2 MEDIA

To contextualise the discursive environment surrounding post-disaster mobility, analysis of different information sources during the first year post disaster - news, social media and third sector reports - was conducted to enable a comparative analysis of how the dynamics were discussed in traditional journalistic coverage, by the general public, and by third sector actors (respectively matching).

4.2.1 NEWS MEDIA COVERAGE

The articles assessed were in Portuguese and English, the primary, “formal” languages of both countries in the study and other reporting outlets. Both countries have local languages common in everyday discourse but not used in media outlets. As shown in Fig 4.2.1.1, news coverage on the disaster peaked soon after the cyclone and drastically reduced within a couple of weeks, subsequently maintaining little to no relative coverage.

Figure 4.2.1.1 Line Graph showing Overall Number of News Articles Over Time



As shown in graphs 4.2.1.2 and 4.2.1.3 below, the overall sentiment of the articles are highly neutral with an overall slightly negative score. In both countries, English articles have a significantly higher average negative sentiment score in comparison to the Portuguese news.

Figure 4.2.1.2 Bar Graph showing News Media Average Sentiment by Country and Language
Figure 4.2.1.3 Bar Graph showing Distribution of News Media Sentiment Scores

Figure 4.2.1.2

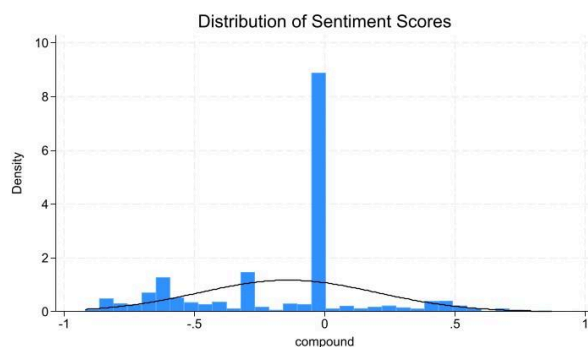
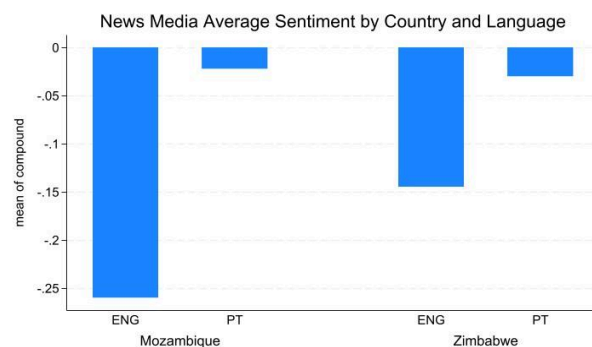
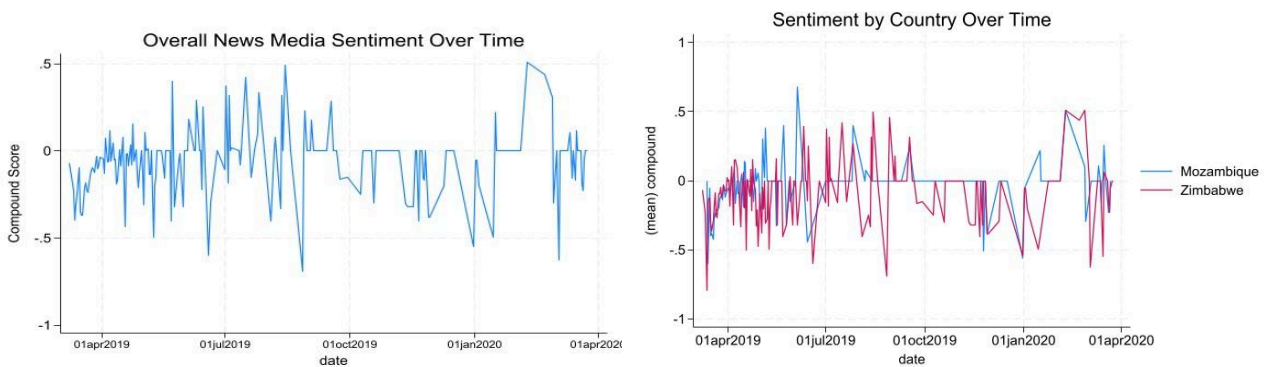


Figure 4.2.1.3



In terms of sentiment over time, the two graphs show a similar highly fluctuating trend in both countries with a notable negative consistent reporting beginning around 6 months post disaster and a new positive sentiment rise picking up at around 9 months after the cyclone.

Figure 4.2.1.4 News Media Sentiment Over Time



4.2.2 SOCIAL MEDIA

This analysis was derived from Youtube data where much of the narratives and reactions from civilians happened in the comment sections of videos that provided coverage of the disaster from angles of losses, humanitarian aid, government interventions and pleas for aid.

After extracting the most relevant 500 videos from the “cyclone idai” search query (see Figure 4.2.2.1), posting on the subject was very high, although over half occurred during the month of the cyclone and drastically dropped, with consistent little to no posting. The comments from the 10 most engaged with videos (see Figure 4.2.2.2) also indicate over 80% of community discourse on the cyclone happening within the month post disaster followed by a drastic drop.

Figure 4.2.2.1 Bar Graph showing Number of Posts Over Time

Figure 4.2.2.2 Bar Graph showing number of Youtube Comments Over Time

Figure 4.2.2.1

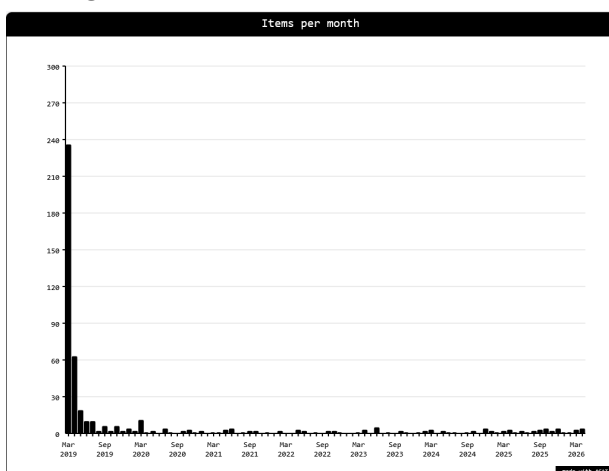
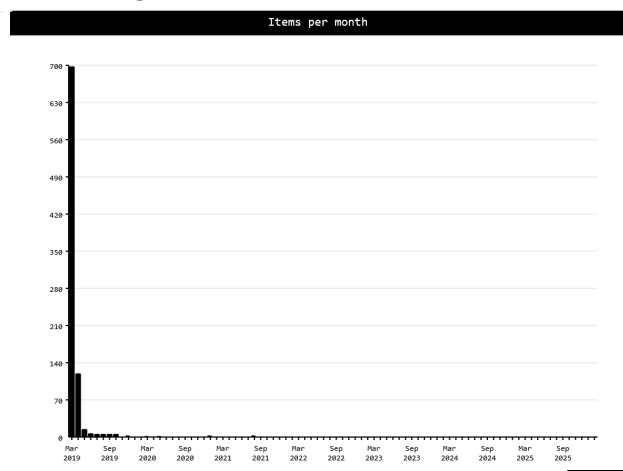


Figure 4.2.2.1



The earlier referenced comments were extracted and the image in Figure 4.2.2.4 illustrates in scaled word form the main themes from the community comments.

Figure 4.2.2.4 Word Cloud Image from Youtube Comments



4.3 THIRD SECTOR REPORTING

Sourcing from Relief Web, this section summarises 41 published news and press releases, situation reports and appeals from major humanitarian organisations.

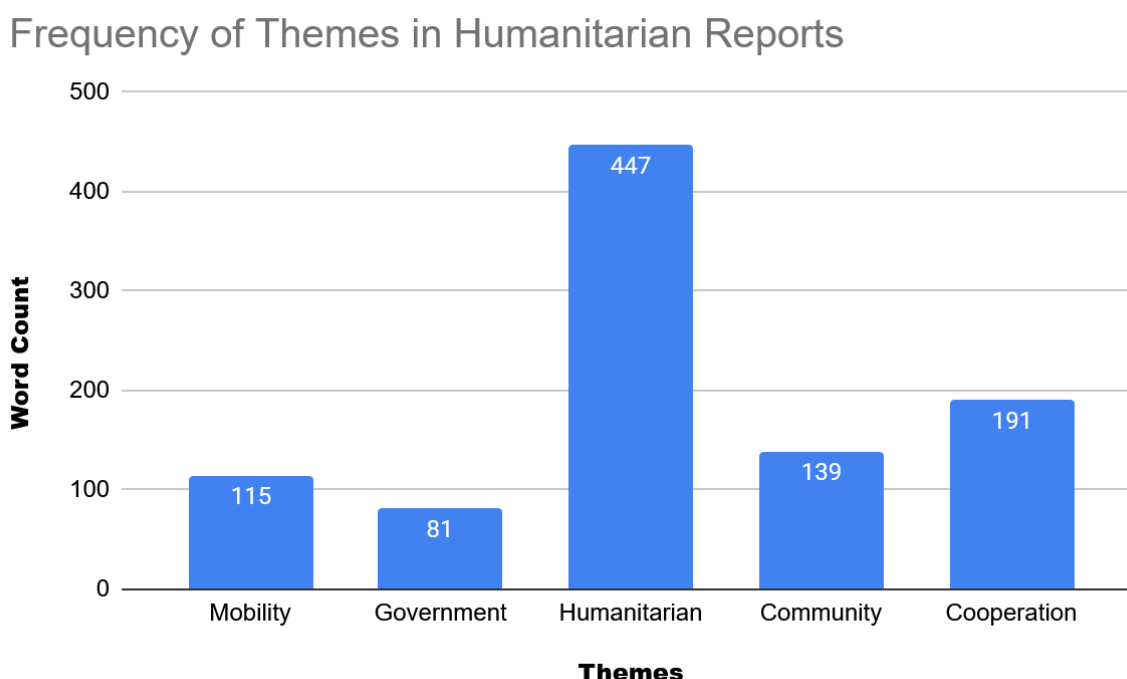
Figure 4.3.1 Main themes from Humanitarian published texts



The image in Figure 4.3.1 shows the main themes from the texts notably “humanitarian,” “cyclone” “response,” “people,” and “report.”

Using word count to establish the focus of the reports, Figure 4.4.2 shows that the majority of the reports focused on humanitarian themes and the least on government action or themes. In comparison to the humanitarian themes, mobility of IDPs is about 25% against humanitarian mentions. However, community and cooperation, though low in mention, remain in the relative middle of count.

Figure 4.2.2.2 showing the frequency of themes in Humanitarian Reports



In terms of framing, table 4.3.1 below shows associated language for each category as shown in the reports.

Table 4.3.1 showing association language of themes in Humanitarian reports

Theme	Collocates	Correlations	phrases
Mobility	people, cyclone, idai, needs, millions, voluntary, wants, families, displaced, work, sites, assessment, swept, providing, able, affected, year, weeks, home,	desperate, humanitarian, people, ingc, allow, airport, affect	moved out of,
Government	release, press, partners, news, national, support, according, african, president	zirp, work, weekend, approaches, allows, appeals, amid, airport	

Humanitarian	protection, support, health, nutrition, office, response, affairs, coordination	humanitarian, release, ocha, response, published, posted,	humanitarian response plan, humanitarian flash appeal, humanitarian partners to
Community	beira, sofala, protection, province, near	remote, replace, rice, responders, route,	city buzi nhamatanda
Cooperation	working, usher, unhcr, team, centre, school, people, displaced, unicef, response, support, need, communities	children, disaster, support, nations, essential, gbv, executive, million, emergency, report, affected, humanitarian, emergency, million	

4.4 CROSS DATA TRIANGULATION

4.4.1 TEMPORAL ATTENTION

There is a stark difference between the mobility peak and narratives in news and social media. Both sources indicate a significant collapse within 1-2months post the cyclone. The IDM data, however, shows that movement and its peaks continued for up to 22 months post the cyclone, marking a difference between when the crisis ended in the data versus the public eye. The later stage recovery dynamics are highly underrepresented in news and social discourse.

4.4.2 MOBILITY AND IMMOBILITY

There is a notable difference in the scale and volatility of Zimbabwean and Mozambique sites, with the latter characterised by high fluctuations and significant flows. This is clear in the IDM data but absent in the reporting narratives.

Across narrative datasets, there is relative absence of immobility which in the quantitative datasets is exhibited through concentration of observations around minimal population change. There is a clear bias of narratives on movement and visible intervention as opposed to the prolonged stasis and constrained agency.

4.4.3 SENTIMENT and NARRATIVE REPRESENTATION

The three groups - official / government reporting represented in the news media, Humanitarian and community narratives indicate different focuses and sentiments. The news media and third sector focused on “resettlement” and “response” while the community, though social media, focused on specific community trauma and immediate survival needs. The high proportion of unclassified settlements indicate a low intricate capturing of the reality of the IDPs accommodations.

As shown in table 4.3.1, Humanitarian reports correlate mobility with “voluntary” and “needs.” The IDM data however shows high volatility- rapid and extreme outflows which rather suggest evacuation or quick decongestions.

Overall findings also show a bias in how different actors intervene. Humanitarian reports highly reference humanitarian actors and coordination dynamics with limited emphasis to government led processes. This is in contrast to the IDM data that indicates organised resettlement in Mozambique and community hosting in Zimbabwe, indicating the significant roles of government and community in mobility pathways.

4.4.4 SUMMARY

Data Convergence	Data Divergence
• peak news coverage align with initial displacement peaks • the positive uptick in news coverage 9 months post cyclone aligns with observed return pulses in Mozambique • Social media data corroborates early inflow and evacuation signals • association of mobility with voluntary in humanitarian reports aligns with episodic returns • differences in site dynamics and the categories in IDM data match showing the hosting smaller scale dynamics of Zimbabwe and more scaled movements in Mozambique	• temporal mismatch between actual mobility and presence of narratives • media does not capture the long term recovery dynamics and immobility • language bias, english articles more negative • Social media represents initial emotional reaction • classification gaps in IDMs

5.0 DISCUSSION

SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

Mozambique experienced larger IDP sites and greater volatility while Zimbabwe's sites were smaller and more stable.

News media and social media concentrated on the immediate aftermath, humanitarian reporting emphasised response significantly over mobility and generally, community discourse was intense but faded quickly.

Public media tended to highlight visible mobility, returns and evacuations while the IDM data indicated substantial immobility.

5.1 RQ1 Mandated Pathways

How are Zimbabwe and Mozambique different in mandated pathways of post disaster mobility and actual mobility patterns after Cyclone Idai?

The data fundamentally shows how both countries managed displacement. Mozambique leaned on resettlement sites (Fig.4.1.1.2) that correspond with larger site size and higher volatility (Fig.4.1.1.2). This resettlement created sharp fluctuations in populations as people were moved into formal structures. Zimbabwe on the other hand relied heavily on host communities that resulted in smaller, more uniform site distributions and gradual return rate (Figure 4.1.3.2). The differences in these pathways mean Mozambique had high volatility and visibility while Zimbabwean movements were less erratic and quiet, consequently documented less.

The contrast between both countries is consistent with literature on humanitarian governance and camp formation, particularly noting Hilhorst (2018) and Barnett's (2011), which argues that state and agency choices about accommodation shape both scale and visibility. In Mozambique, where priority was given to centralised resettlement, volumes and concentrations of IDPs were high. In Zimbabwe, consistent with Black (2014), reliance on community based solutions can render less visible but more enduring placements. In this case, the burden of recovery is shifted from the state and absorbed by existing social networks, explained by Manyena (2006) on the concept of resilience.

This distinction supports the argument that governance frameworks do not merely respond to displacement but actively produce different "mobility regimes" (Cresswell, 2010), shaping both the scale and visibility of movement.

5.2 RQ2 Public Media VS Community and Third Sector Narratives

To what extent do the role, contributions and effectiveness of interventions in public media narratives align with the specific sentiments expressed by the community and third sector separately?

There is a temporal alignment between news and social media, both being significant at the beginning of the crisis and rapidly dropping within two months. This is explained by the concepts of "Compassion Fatigue" (Moeller, 1999) and "Politics of Pity" (Boltanski, 1999) which argue that in a classic media cycle of disaster, news focuses on the spectacle, in this case the cyclone's heavy rains and subsequent deaths, but ignores the chronic phase, the displacement of people.

The short-lived attention to Cyclone Idai reflects salience transfer mechanics, where media gatekeeping dictates public priorities (Downs, 1972). As an unobtrusive issue for global audiences, Idai lacked a "social anchor," causing interest to collapse once the issue-attention cycle moved from dramatic discovery to mundane recovery (Agenda Setting Theory, 2026). This decay was driven by media logic favoring culturally proximate "elite nation" events, such as Brexit or the Notre Dame fire, and digital crisis fatigue, which prioritizes trending "clickbait" over sustained engagement.

There is however a mixed sentiment among the news and social media. News media, especially English news media outlets, were more negative than Portuguese outlets. While community sentiments were emotionally and spiritually charged, they did not sustain the negative phases that continued to show in the news media. Therefore, while both media narratives capture the immediate shock, the progression was much quicker to drop in social media thus not amplifying the ongoing issues such as recovery.

Comparing all three, a difference in themes focus can be observed. News media remained largely neutral (Figure 4.2.1.2), community via social media focused on the localised pleas of the affected community (Figure 4.2.2.4) while the third sector primarily focused on "protection" and "coordination", mentioning mobility but outside the central focus (Figure 4.2.2.4).

The lack of government mentions in humanitarian reports suggests that the third sector operated in operational autonomy focusing solely on their response plans rather than an integrated one. This could explain the fluctuating sentiments in public media narratives, reflecting the friction between humanitarian plans versus the community and its mandated reality.

All the data shows the differences in perceived effectiveness. Community discourse emphasized unmet needs and urgent assistance while the third sector reported response achievements and plans. However, all media prioritised humanitarian response over mobility because aid delivery is more consumable for audiences, classic "spectatorship of suffering" phenomenon (Chouliaraki, 2006) than the complex reality of long term immobility.

5.3 RQ3 Immobility in Public Documentation

What do the datasets reveal about the reality of immobility and return versus publicly available documentation?

Traditionally, displacement is viewed in the binary lens of move and return (Black and Coyller 2014). This is seen in this case. The IDM reveals persistent immobility that is underplayed or absent in public narratives. Many sites cluster around zero change, indicating long term immobility. The news and humanitarian reports focus on visible movements (returns and evacuations) and program related milestones like the appeals and response plans.

All public documentation (humanitarian and news media) highlight success events with the mention of “humanitarian response plans,” “resettlement,” “appeals,” all which amplify action rather than the absence of movement. The reality of immobility is hidden in the “Unclassified/Unknown” site category (Figure 4.1.2). Lubkemann’s (2008) work on “displacement in place” argues that these populations in unclassified sites represent the IDPs that are neither settled or returned. Documents however focus on the movement, the resettling and return which is not the “stable” displacement shown in the IDM data.

5.4 Main RQ Cyclone Idai Actor Dynamics and Mobility

How did the interaction between national governance frameworks and humanitarian actor dynamics shape post-disaster mobility outcomes across a spectrum of movement (from immobility to return) following Cyclone Idai in Mozambique and Zimbabwe?

Government frameworks set the mobility pathways but however did not control the outcomes. Mozambique’s had emphasised resettlement and emergency accommodation while Zimbabwe made use of host communities and facilitated return. The mobility outcomes however were a result of the interactions between both humanitarian actor dynamics and governance choices.

Humanitarian actors’ operational focus through camp management, distribution and resettlement programming, shaped both physical movement, through assistance and site services and public narratives, through situation reports and appeals. Third-sector emphasis on response and needs likely incentivised returns where assistance enabled reconstruction or transport, and conversely, lack of sustained programming contributed to persistent immobility in many sites. The autonomous operational dynamics indicated in the humanitarian reporting suggests a lack of the Humanitarian-Development nexus (Barnett and Weiss, 2011). The interaction was a parallel partnership, with humanitarian actors focusing on survival logistics in temporary settlements while the government focused on land logistics, provision of resettlement land.

Overall, the dynamics produced heterogeneous outcomes with some sites experiencing rapid influx whereas others, despite the public narrative, remained immobile. Ultimately, the outcome of mobility was less about the cyclone itself but a by-product of the size and categorization of the sites and the competing logics of the responders. The combined actions therefore created a pattern resulting in long term mobility and immobility.

6.0 CONCLUSION

6.1 SUMMARY

The study set out to examine how the interactions between government, humanitarian actors and the community shaped mobility outcomes post cyclone-Idai in Zimbabwe and Mozambique. Through a mixed method approach analysing IDM data, public narratives through news and social media as well as humanitarian reports to reveal the uneven landscape of displacement, immobility and return.

Quantitatively, Mozambique reflected massive and volatile sites, reflecting the government's resettlement oriented policy. Zimbabwe on the other hand displayed smaller stable sites and gradual returns that are consistent with the reliance on its host communities and decentralised recovery paths. These findings show that mandated pathways influence the scale and modality of disaster mobility.

Qualitatively, public narratives all focused on selective fragments of the disaster. Social media and news media intensely focused on the immediate aftermath of the disaster, sensationalising the immediate suffering while ignoring the long term displacement reality. Humanitarian reporting however focused on their "success milestones" rather than the mobility related realities. Immobility was significantly reflected in the quantitative data yet absent in the public documentation which raises concern on the invisibility of trapped IDPs in literature and public media.

6.2 IMPLICATIONS

6.2.1 THEORETICAL

There is a need to expand the categorisations of IDP populations to include those stuck in long periods of immobility.

Future studies should utilise a consortium of data sources and analysis tools for holistic approaches on disaster related mobilities.

It is useful to increasingly conduct comparative studies for better contextual understanding of mobility patterns outside broad frameworks such as "developing countries," or "African countries."

6.2.2 POLICY AND PRACTICE

National frameworks must account for "informal" mobility. By only funding resettlement or return, governance frameworks effectively trap those who cannot fit into these two boxes.

The monitoring of mobility post disaster should be improved, to better and consistently classify sites and humanitarian assistance in a way that aligns with the reality on the ground.

All actors should design interventions that tackle the invisible “immobile” populations post disaster.

Humanitarian actors must integrate their reporting with national governance to avoid operating in the institutional autonomy identified in this research.

Official media outlets need to be more inclusive in reporting the complete picture that accurately reflects the lived experiences.

6.3 FINAL REFLECTION

Ultimately, Cyclone Idai was beyond just heavy winds and rains. It is a complex event where the vulnerable affected population’s mobility and movement agency was in the hands of a network of actors with different goals and narratives. Seven years later, the wounds and scars of the affected populations remain, long after the media, the government and humanitarian actors have long moved on.

APPENDICES

Table 3.6 Missing Data in observations

Missing Data	Mozambique	Zimbabwe	Total
	20	16	36

Table 4.1.1 Percentage Distribution of IDP Site Categories

Country	Emergency/ Collective Center	Host Community/ Family	Other/ Unclassified	Resettlement Site	Return	Spontaneous/ Informal
Mozambique	12.16617211	0	53.48664688	32.41839763	0	1.928783383
Zimbabwe	1.040416166	26.8507403	47.09883954	0	25.010004	0

Table 4.1.3 Table of Comparative Mobility Flows per Country

Key

Movement | Number of Observations
| Percentage of Flow

Movement	Mozambique	Zimbabwe	Total
Inflow	1,295 99.39	1,324 99.32	2,619 99.36
Outflow	5 0.38	9 0.68	14 0.53
Stable	3 .023	0 0	3 0.11
Total	1,303 100	1,333 100	2,636 100

Table 4.3.1 showing association language of themes in Humanitarian reports

Mobility	115
Government	81
Humanitarian	447
Community	139
Cooperation	191

CODEBOOK AND DATA SETS



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